



satraps to defeat the incumbents.

The Congress, though, was wiser. Both Prime Minister Manmohan Singh and Congress President Sonia Gandhi made only symbolic appearances in the campaign. Sonia didn't even bother to visit many states during the first round. And son Rahul Gandhi kept himself away from the battlegrounds after a disastrous experience in the Gujarat elections. The Congress high command left the selection of candidates and the campaign strategy entirely to local leaders. The big daddies of the BJP were everywhere; they flew across the states in chartered planes. The BJP's prime ministerial candidate, L.K. Advani, and party President Rajnath Singh even skipped the all-party meeting convened by the prime minister following 26/11 as they thought campaigning was more urgent. There was total disconnect between what the local leaders projected and what was being espoused by the central leadership.

The message can't be missed by those who aspire to rule India. Power at the Centre can no longer be sustained without strong political input from the provinces. The Centre can impose leaders on the states but, on its own, it cannot win an election. Welcome to the age of the strong state and the weak Centre. And the BJP will be the most affected in this age. With the retirement of its most popular

leader Atal Bihari Vajpayee, the party's vanguard is formed by leaders like Gujarat Chief Minister Narendra Modi, Madhya Pradesh Chief Minister Shivraj Chouhan, former Rajasthan chief minister Vasundhara Raje, Chhattisgarh Chief Minister Raman Singh, party Vice-President Gopinath Munde, Karnataka Chief Minister B.S. Yeddyurappa, General Secretary Ananth Kumar and Rajnath Singh. They are fighters and winners, and most of them are mentored by the party's first charioteer Advani. He has not let a new set of younger leaders grow, and remains heavily dependent on not street-fighters but apparatchiks. The BJP doesn't have a leader worth its salt in states like Haryana, Punjab, Bihar, Tamil Nadu, Andhra Pradesh, West Bengal, Orissa and in the Northeast. The Congress doesn't exist in more than 250 seats in the country, and the party's destiny is dictated by the impulses of the Dynasty. The party that ruled the country for almost

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five decades has not crossed the 150 mark in the Lok Sabha since 1996 because it has systematically demolished the state structures. Lessons of December for the big two of Indian politics:

- Nepotism will not win elections;
- Give more political autonomy to state leaders;
- Honesty and leadership matter more than sycophancy;
- Choose leaders who can lead and govern;
- Make development the campaign mantra.

Will the national leadership now let winners from the states take the centrestage? This question was asked when leaders like Nehru and Indira Gandhi were around. While Nehru allowed powerful state satraps to co-exist, Mrs Gandhi was ruthless in neutralising them. The result was the emergence of regional parties formed by former Congressmen or caste leaders who were denied a stake in power. Those who followed Indira to lead the party never got the same mandate; even her son Rajiv Gandhi became the first Gandhi who failed to get a second term. Sonia is yet to become the restorer of glory.

Now that the state elections have turned out to be a draw, neither of the parties can approach Elections 2009 with certainty. They need winnable allies and credible candidates. With national leaders of both parties lacking pan-India appeal and acceptability, a syndicate of regional leaders is likely to choose the next ruler in Delhi. The Left may become the kingmaker again if the NDA and the UPA fail to cross the 150 mark. We are headed for a longer season of rule by a national leadership that can't win a state but is controlled by leaders who can win the states. ■